

social media who through their posting encourage you to act in a way that is minimising your weakness.

Which leads me to ask: Is there someone with great self-control or with financial habits you admire who you could place in your life? Be it online, offline, in your social circle, in your family group or otherwise?

Of course, while we can curate positive Money Environments that benefit us, we can also unwittingly be cultivating negative ones. Think about the adage 'Keeping up with the Joneses'. Comparing ourselves to our neighbours isn't a modern phenomenon. The phrase 'Keeping up with the Joneses' was originally the title of Arthur 'Pop' Momand's comic strip in *The New York Globe* that began in 1913—depicting the social climbing McGinis family and their attempts to 'keep up' with their next-door neighbours the Joneses.

What is unique today is *who* we compare ourselves to. That's because today, thanks to social media, many of us compare ourselves to our peers around the globe—not just our immediate neighbourhood—and find ourselves wanting. While this global comparison culture may take a psychological toll, it's the detrimental financial effect that I'm most concerned about.

To explore this further, let's look at a study conducted by the Federal Reserve Bank of Philadelphia titled 'Does the Relative Income of Peers Cause Financial Distress? Evidence from lottery winners and neighboring bankruptcies'. The researchers looked at Canadian data relating to lottery winners and bankruptcy claims from 2004 to 2014, centring on people who won less than \$150,000. They discovered that the bigger the lottery win in a neighbourhood, the more cases of bankruptcy there tended to be in the same area.

To be clear, it wasn't the lottery winners that were going bankrupt; it was their neighbours.

The researchers discovered that where the lottery winner spent more on visible goods, such as cars, renovations and holidays, their neighbours also tended to spend more on conspicuous goods and invest more in speculative investments. The neighbours compared themselves to their lotto-winning neighbour, and felt they needed to 'keep up' with their consumption, despite not having received a financial wind-fall themselves. Of course, with this increased spending on the part of those non-lottery-